

BAMBOO RATS AND RELATIVES

The family Spalacidae includes blind mole rats, bamboo rats, root rats, and zokors. Big, protruding incisors characterize the blind mole rats. Adapted to an underground life, they have no external eyes and ears. The bamboo rats of eastern Asia have visible eyes.



17–35 cm
6½–14 in

GREATER MOLE RAT

Spalax microphthalmus

This blind species has sensory bristles running from its snout to its eye sockets. It is native to the steppes of Ukraine and S.E. Russia.



15–26 cm
6–10 in

LESSER BAMBOO RAT

Cannomys badius

Found from Nepal to Vietnam, this single species of its genus digs deep burrows in forests, grassy areas, and sometimes gardens.

SPRINGHARES

Resembling rabbits in size and behaviour, the Pedetidae differ in producing only one young at a time. They breed all year round, but living in dry, open habitats makes them vulnerable to predators.



33–46 cm
13–18 in

EAST AFRICAN SPRINGHARE

Pedetes surdaster

Springhares escape their nocturnal predators with kangaroo-like leaps. Less common than *Pedetes capensis*, this species lives on the Serengeti plain in Africa.

SOUTH AFRICAN SPRINGHARE

Pedetes capensis

This species leaves its burrow at night to nibble at the grass and herbs found in the dry regions of southern Africa.

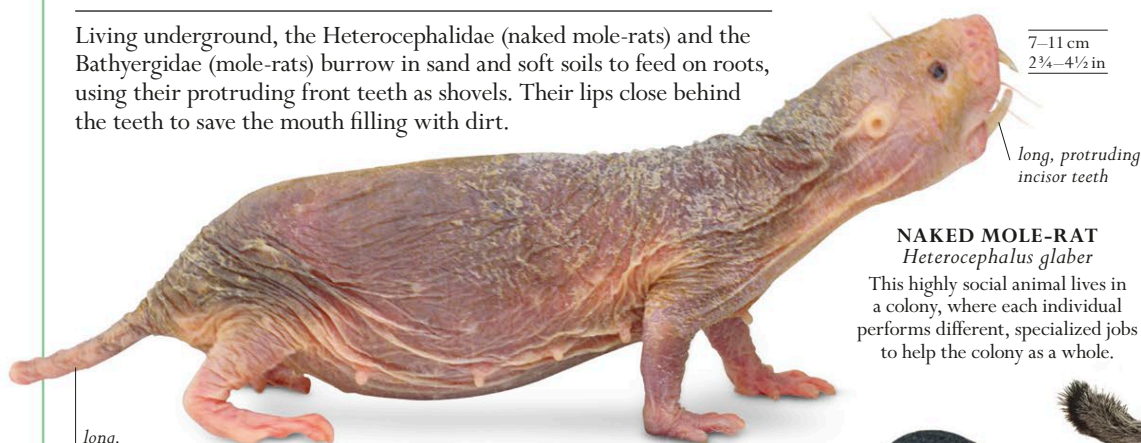


33–46 cm
13–18 in

long
tufted tail

AFRICAN MOLE-RATS

Living underground, the Heterocephalidae (naked mole-rats) and the Bathyergidae (mole-rats) burrow in sand and soft soils to feed on roots, using their protruding front teeth as shovels. Their lips close behind the teeth to save the mouth filling with dirt.



7–11 cm
2¾–4½ in

long, protruding
incisor teeth

NAKED MOLE-RAT

Heterocephalus glaber

This highly social animal lives in a colony, where each individual performs different, specialized jobs to help the colony as a whole.



10–19 cm
4–7½ in

COMMON MOLE-RAT

Cryptomys hottentotus

Found from Tanzania to South Africa, this common species lives in soft soils and farmland, where it feeds mainly on roots.

NAMAQUA DUNE MOLE-RAT

Bathyergus janetta

Native to Namibia and southwestern South Africa, this species uses its forefeet rather than its teeth to dig burrows.



17–24 cm
6½–9½ in

NEW WORLD PORCUPINES

Tree-dwelling animals in American forests, the Erethizontidae have short spines, which are generally less than 10 cm (4 in) long. Most have a prehensile tail to grip branches.



0.6–1.3 m
2–4¼ ft

NORTH AMERICAN PORCUPINE

Erethizon dorsatus

This forest dweller is found throughout N. America, from Alaska to Mexico. Its spines are hidden among its shaggy fur.



44–56 cm
17½–22 in

BRAZILIAN PORCUPINE

Coendou prehensilis

This nocturnal species inhabits forested areas of S. America and Trinidad. It sleeps by day and forages for leaves and shoots at dusk.



spines are
modified
hair

OLD WORLD PORCUPINES

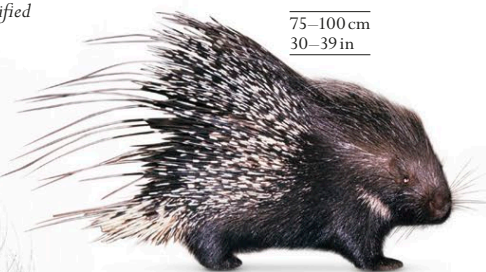
Found across most of Africa and southern Asia, the 11 species of the family Hystricidae family live in burrows. They are covered with long, stiff quills that protect them against most predators. When attacked, they often rattle their quills as a reminder of how sharp and impenetrable these are.

CRESTED PORCUPINE

Hystrix cristata

45–93 cm
18–36½ in

Widespread across the northern half of Africa, except the Sahara, the crested porcupine is a familiar nocturnal rodent.



75–100 cm
30–39 in

CAPE PORCUPINE

Hystrix africae australis

Found in savanna across most of southern Africa, this species forages at night, alone or in groups, sniffing out roots and berries.